

MOCK EXAMINATION — TRY BEFORE YOU BOOK

GCSE English Language

Mock Test & Mark Scheme

Time allowed	35 minutes
Total marks	60 marks
Number of questions	25
Topics covered	Reading comprehension, language & structure analysis, SPaG (spelling, punctuation & grammar), and descriptive/narrative writing

Student name: _____ **Date:** _____

Instructions

- Answer every question in the space provided on your own paper.
- Write your name and today's date at the top of your answer sheet.
- The marks for each question are shown in brackets, e.g. **(2 marks)**.
- Where a calculation is required, show your working — marks are available for method as well as the final answer.
- Once you finish, check your answers against the mark scheme at the back of this document.
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Section A: Reading

Read the passage below, then answer the questions that follow. Marks for each question are shown in brackets.

The Lighthouse Keeper's Daughter

Mira had lived on the island for as long as she could remember, though her mother always said three years felt like forever when you were only eight. Every evening, she climbed the sixty-three steps to the lighthouse lamp room, counting them under her breath the way her father had taught her, and every evening the number was the same. It was one of the few certainties left since the fishing boats had stopped coming.

Tonight the sea was the colour of hammered tin, restless beneath a sky that could not decide whether to storm. Mira pressed her palm against the cold glass and watched the beam sweep out across the water, slow and patient, the way her father moved when he mended the nets. She wondered, not for the first time, whether the light ever grew tired of turning.

'You're thinking too loudly again,' her father said from the doorway, though he was smiling when he said it. He carried two mugs of something that steamed in the evening air, and he set hers on the sill beside her before settling into the old wicker chair that had belonged to his own father.

'Do you think anyone's out there?' Mira asked. 'Tonight, I mean.'

Her father considered this for longer than she expected. 'Someone's always out there,' he said eventually. 'That's rather the point of the light.'

Mira turned back to the window. Somewhere beyond the reach of the beam, the dark was enormous and complete, and yet she found she was no longer afraid of it — only curious about everything it might be hiding.

1. According to the passage, how many steps lead up to the lamp room? **[1 mark]**
2. Give two details from the passage that show Mira has a close relationship with her father. **[2 marks]**
3. Explain how the writer uses language to describe the sea in the second paragraph. Refer to at least one technique in your answer. **[4 marks]**
4. How does the writer structure the passage to build a sense of atmosphere before the father appears? **[3 marks]**
5. 'The passage suggests that light can represent hope even in difficult times.' To what extent do you agree? Support your answer with reference to the text. **[5 marks]**
6. Find and copy one word from the third paragraph that means 'gave off steam'. **[1 mark]**

7. What does the line 'You're thinking too loudly again' suggest about how well the father understands Mira? **[2 marks]**
8. Explain the effect of the word 'enormous' in the final paragraph. **[2 marks]**

Section B: Language Skills

Short questions on spelling, punctuation, grammar and vocabulary. Marks for each question are shown in brackets.

9. Identify the word class (part of speech) of the underlined word: 'She ran quickly to the door.' [1 mark]
10. Punctuate the following sentence correctly: *the dog ran into the garden and barked loudly* [1 mark]
11. Identify the main clause in this sentence: 'Although it was raining, we went for a walk.' [1 mark]
12. Which is the correct spelling: 'recieve' or 'receive'? [1 mark]
13. Insert the missing apostrophe: *The dogs bone was buried in the garden.* [1 mark]
14. Identify whether this sentence is simple, compound or complex: 'I like tea, but I prefer coffee.' [1 mark]
15. Rewrite this sentence in the passive voice: 'The cat chased the mouse.' [2 marks]
16. Identify the verb in this sentence: 'The children played happily in the park.' [1 mark]
17. Correct the grammatical error in this sentence: 'Me and him went to the shop.' [1 mark]
18. Give one synonym for the word 'happy'. [1 mark]
19. Give one antonym for the word 'expand'. [1 mark]
20. Identify the sentence type: 'What time is it?' [1 mark]
21. Add the correct punctuation to this sentence: *wait she shouted dont go* [2 marks]
22. Identify the tense used in this sentence: 'She had already left when I arrived.' [1 mark]
23. Explain the difference between 'their', 'there' and 'they're', giving an example of each. [3 marks]
24. Identify the simile in this sentence: 'The moon was like a silver coin in the sky.' [1 mark]

Section C: Writing

Writing task [20 marks]

Describe a place that feels different at night than it does during the day. You could write about a real place or an imagined one.

Aim to write 1½–2 sides. You will be marked on your use of vocabulary, sentence variety, organisation, and the accuracy of your spelling, punctuation and grammar.

Mark Scheme

Section A: Reading — indicative content

Q	Indicative content / mark scheme guidance	Marks
1	63 (sixty-three)	1
2	Any two relevant, textually supported details, e.g.: he brings her a hot drink and sets it beside her; he teases her gently while smiling (“You’re thinking too loudly again”); he answers her question thoughtfully rather than dismissing it; he sits with her in the lamp room.	2
3	Look for identification of technique(s) such as the simile “colour of hammered tin” (suggesting the sea looks hard, cold or dull), and the comparison of the lighthouse beam’s movement to the father mending nets (“slow and patient”), linking setting to character. Award marks for: identifying a technique (1), naming it correctly (1), explaining its effect with reference to the text (2).	4
4	Look for comment on: the opening focus on routine and repetition (counting steps) creating a steady, watchful mood; the description of the uncertain sky and restless sea building tension; the shift in pace and mood once the father arrives. Award up to 3 marks for the range and quality of structural observations made.	3
5	Look for a clear personal response supported by relevant textual reference, e.g.: the recurring image of the beam sweeping “slow and patient” suggests constancy; the father’s line “someone’s always out there...that’s rather the point of the light” implies the light exists for the unseen, for hope beyond what can be confirmed; Mira’s shift from wondering if the light “grows tired” to no longer being “afraid” of the dark suggests personal reassurance. Reward developed, textually supported responses with a clear viewpoint; award partial credit for less developed responses.	5
6	“steamed”	1
7	It suggests he can read her mood and silences without her having to explain, implying a close, perceptive, long-standing relationship between them.	2
8	It emphasises the vast scale of the darkness beyond the lighthouse beam, which contrasts with Mira’s calm, curious response rather than fear — heightening how significant her change in feeling is.	2
Section A total		20 marks

Section B: Language Skills — mark scheme

Q	Answer	Marks
9	Adverb	1

Q	Answer	Marks
10	The dog ran into the garden and barked loudly.	1
11	"we went for a walk"	1
12	receive	1
13	The dog's bone was buried in the garden.	1
14	Compound	1
15	The mouse was chased by the cat.	2
16	"played"	1
17	"He and I went to the shop."	1
18	E.g. joyful, glad, or pleased.	1
19	E.g. shrink or contract.	1
20	Question (interrogative sentence)	1
21	'Wait!' she shouted. 'Don't go!'	2
22	Past perfect tense	1
23	'Their' shows possession (e.g. "their house"); 'there' refers to a place (e.g. "over there"); 'they're' is short for 'they are' (e.g. "they're leaving").	3
24	"like a silver coin"	1
Section B total		20 marks

Section C: Writing — band descriptors

Writing is marked holistically against the bands below — find the band that best matches the piece overall, then fine-tune the exact mark within that band.

Band	Marks	Descriptor
Band 4	16–20	Confident, controlled descriptive writing. Wide range of vocabulary and sentence structures used for deliberate effect. Well-organised with a clear sense of structure. Accurate spelling, punctuation and grammar throughout.
Band 3	11–15	Clear, secure descriptive writing. A range of vocabulary and some variation in sentence structures. Generally well organised. Mostly accurate spelling, punctuation and grammar with occasional errors.

Band	Marks	Descriptor
Band 2	6–10	Some descriptive detail, though may be inconsistent. Vocabulary and sentence structures are simple but generally appropriate. Some organisation evident. Frequent errors that may affect meaning at times.
Band 1	1–5	Limited descriptive detail. Vocabulary and sentence structures are basic and repetitive. Little evidence of organisation. Frequent errors that often affect meaning.
Total for English Language		60 marks

How did you do? A BrainyEdHub tutor can go through any question you got stuck on, and give you detailed, personalised feedback on your writing. Book a free trial class at brainyedhub.com/contact.html or message us on WhatsApp.